

# ART & CULTURE



## INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

### MODULE - 7

#### MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

- SOURCES OF MAURYAN ART
- ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

# MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

## ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE



- 1 Viharas
- 2 Chaityas
- 3 Stupas
- 4 Pillars and Capitals
- 5 Sculptures
- 6 Rock-cut Caves
- 7 Palaces
- 8 Pottery



## A QUICK SUMMARY OF EVENTS...



- 1** Sixth century BCE marks the beginning of new religious and social movements in the Gangetic valley in the form of Buddhism and Jainism which were part of the shraman tradition.
- 2** Both religions became popular as they opposed the varna and jati systems of the Hindu religion.
- 3** Magadha emerged as a powerful kingdom and consolidated its control over the other regions.
- 4** By the fourth century BCE the Mauryas established their power and by the third century BCE, a large part of India was under Mauryan control.

## A QUICK SUMMARY OF EVENTS...

**5** Ashoka emerged as the most powerful king of the Mauryan dynasty who patronized buddhism in the 3<sup>rd</sup> century BC.

**6** Religious practices had many dimensions and were not confined to just one particular mode of worship.

**7** **Worship of Yakshas** and mother goddesses were prevalent during that time. So, multiple forms of worship existed.

**8** Nevertheless, **Buddhism** became the most popular social and religious movement.

**9** **Yaksha worship** was very popular before and after the advent of Buddhism and it **was assimilated into Buddhism and Jainism**.

**10** Construction of stupas and viharas as part of monastic establishments became part of the Buddhist tradition.

**11** However, in this period, apart from stupas and viharas, stone pillars, rock-cut caves and monumental figure sculptures were carved at several places.

## TIMELINE

### HARAPPAN CIVILIZATION

- Early Phase- Approximately 4000 BC to 2550 BC
- Mature phase- 2550 BC to 1900 BC
- Late Phase- 1900 BC to 1500 BC

### VEDIC PHASE

1500 BC to 1000 BC

### LATER VEDIC PHASE

1000 BC to 500 BC

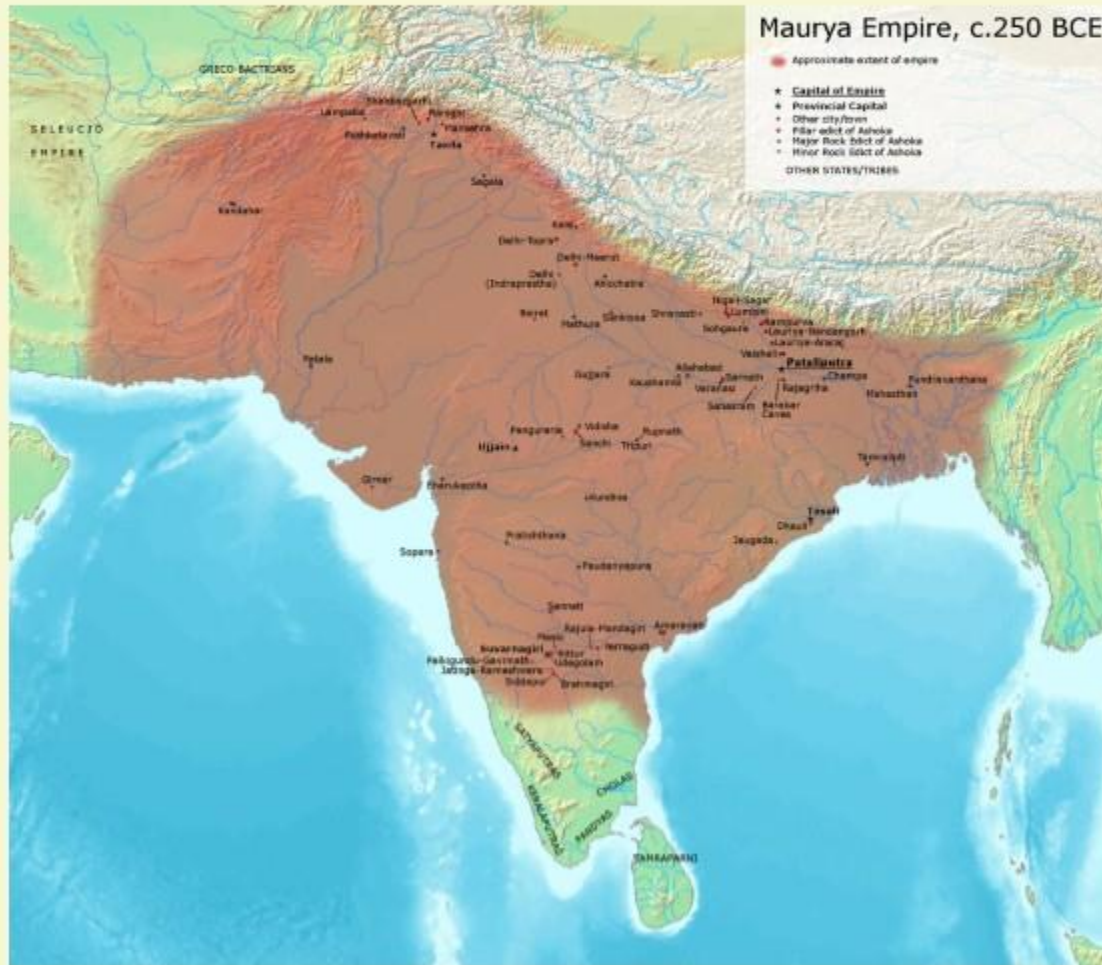
### MAHAJANAPADAS; RISE AND GROWTH OF MAGADHAN EMPIRE

600 BC to 320 BC

### MAURYAN EMPIRE

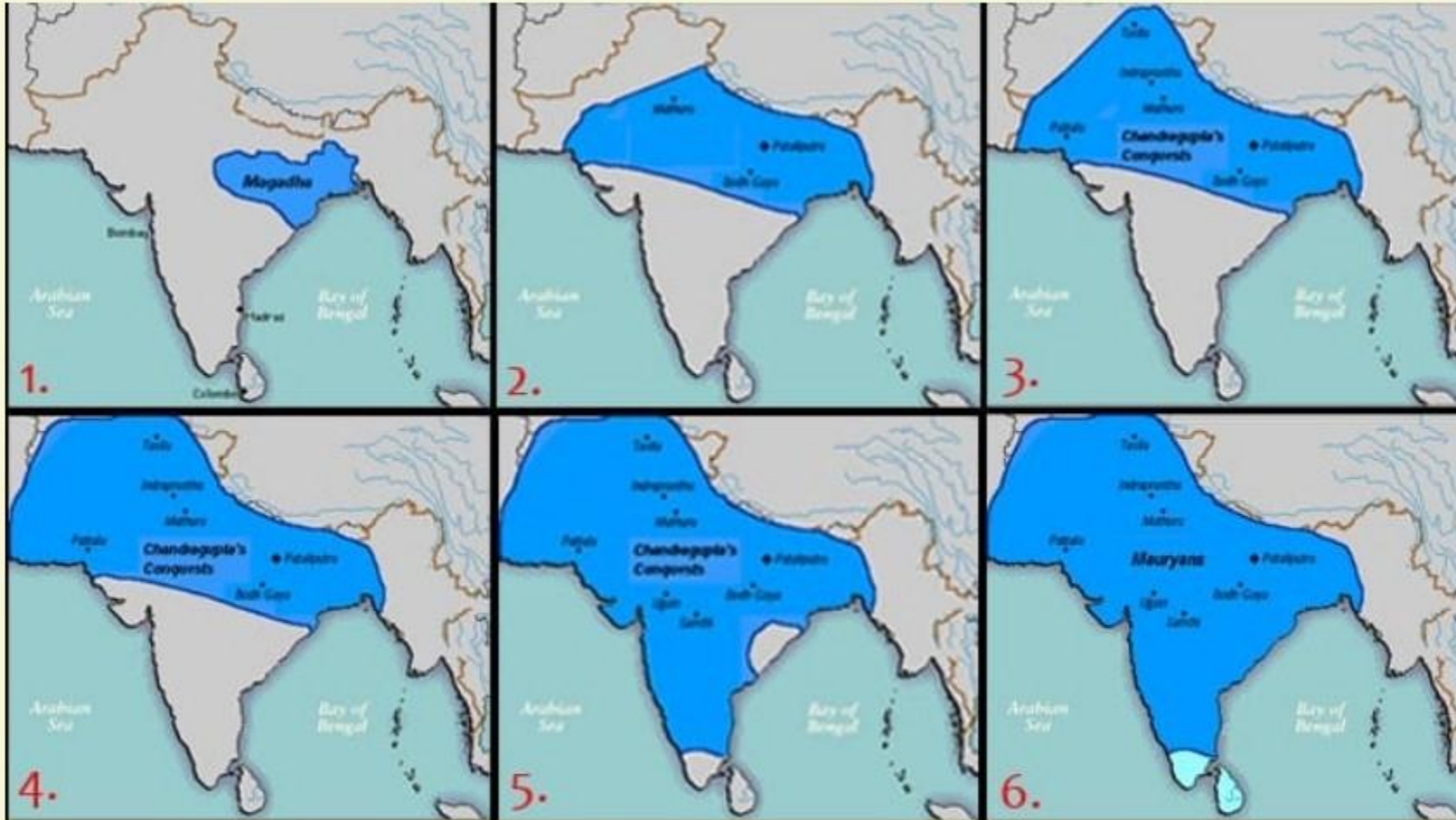
320 BC to 232 BC

# MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE



- 1 The foundation of the Mauryan Empire opens a new era in the history of India.
- 2 For the first time, the political unity was achieved in India.
- 3 Moreover, the history writing has also become clear from this period due to accuracy in chronology and sources.
- 4 Besides plenty of indigenous and foreign literary sources, a number of epigraphical records are also available to write the history of this period.

# MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE



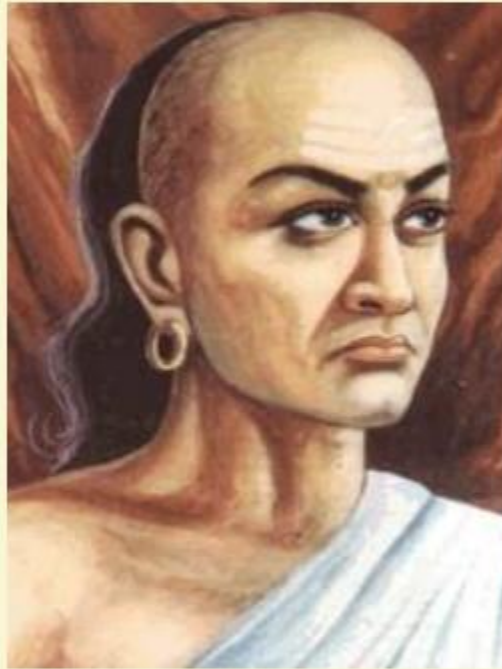
1. Magadha
2. Nanda dynasty
3. Formation of Mauryan empire

4. Chandragupta's expansion to west.
5. Mauryan empire under Bindusara
6. Mauryan empire under Ashoka

# MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

## LITERARY SOURCES

### 1 KAUTILYA'S ARTHASASTRA



- 1 This book in Sanskrit was written by Kautilya, a contemporary of Chandragupta Maurya.
- 2 Kautilya was also called 'Indian Machiavelli'.
- 3 The manuscript of Arthasastra was first discovered by R. Shamasastry in 1904.

Left: Shamasastry, the man who discovered the book, Arthasastra  
Right: Kautilya, the man who wrote the book.

# MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

## LITERARY SOURCES

### 1 KAUTILYA'S ARTHASASTRA



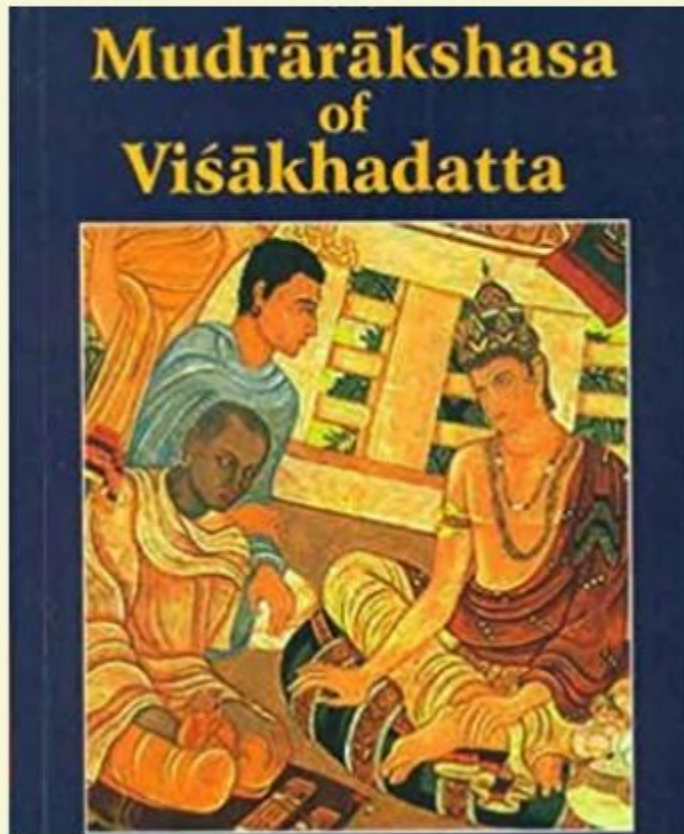
Chanakya- the Kingmaker

- 4 The Arthasastra contains 15 books and 180 chapters but it can be divided into three parts:
  - The first deals with the king and his council and the departments of Government.
  - The second with civil and criminal law.
  - The third with diplomacy and war.
- 5 It is the most important literary source for the history of the Mauryas.

# MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

## LITERARY SOURCES

### 2 VISAKADATTA'S MUDRARAKSHASA



- 1 The Mudrarakshasa written by Visakadatta is a drama in Sanskrit.
- 2 Although written during the Gupta period, it describes how Chandragupta with the assistance of Kautilya overthrew the Nandas.
- 3 It also gives a picture on the socio-economic condition under the Mauryas.

# MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

## LITERARY SOURCES

3

### MEGASTHENES' INDICA



**Megasthenes, the Greek ambassador**

- 1 Megasthenes was the **Greek ambassador** in the court of Chandragupta Maurya.
- 2 His **book Indica** has survived only in **fragments**. Yet, his account gives details about the **Mauryan administration**, particularly the administration of the **capital city of Pataliputra** and also the **military organization**.
- 3 His picture on contemporary social life is notable. Certain unbelievable information provided by him has to be treated with caution.

# MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

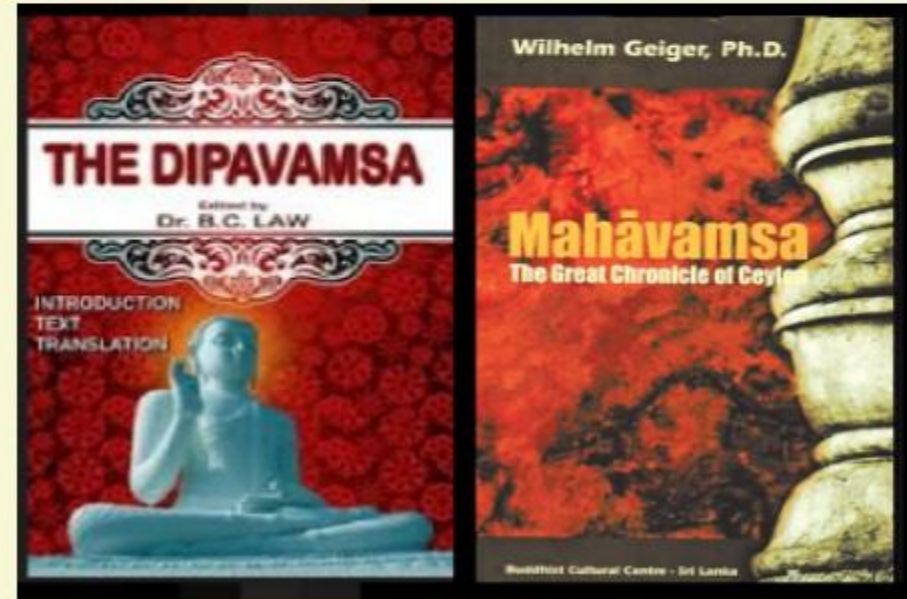
## OTHER LITERARY SOURCES

**1** Apart from these three important works, the Puranas and the Buddhist literature such as Jatakas provide information on the Mauryas.



Jataka tales

**2** The Ceylonese Chronicles Dipavamsa and Mahavamsa throw light on the role Asoka in spreading Buddhism in Sri Lanka.



Dipavamsa & Mahavamsa

# MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

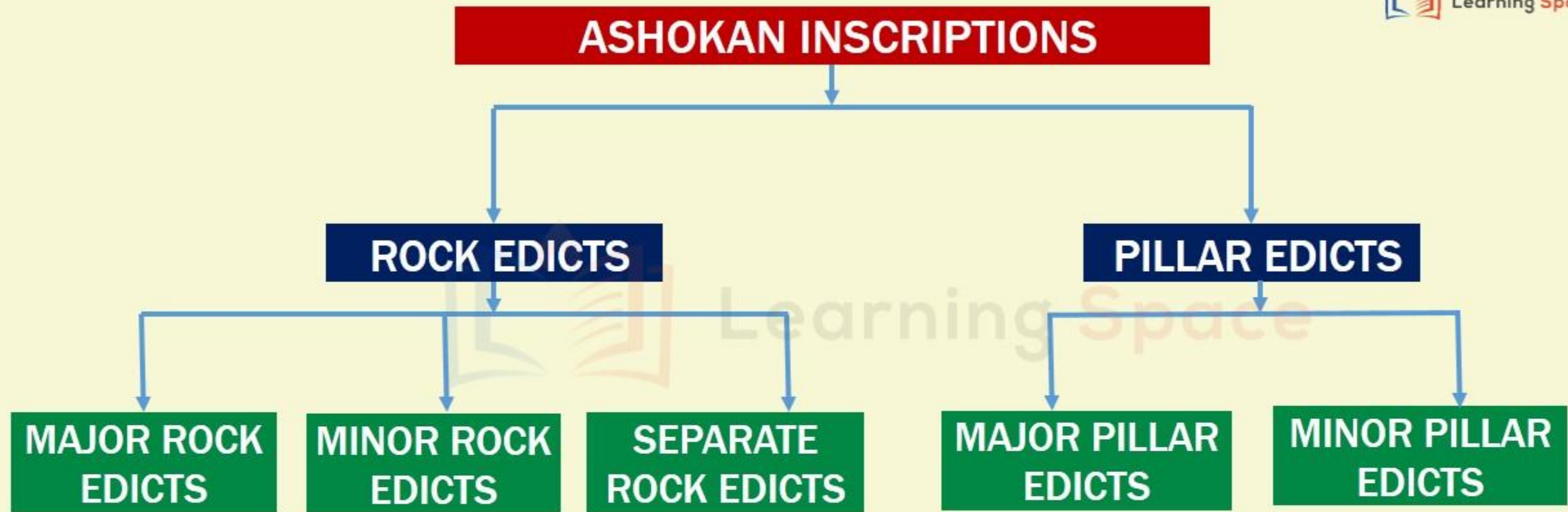
## ARCHAEOLOGICAL SOURCES

### EDICTS OF ASHOKA



The Kandahar Edict of Ashoka, a bilingual inscription (Greek and Aramaic) by king Ashoka

- 1 The inscriptions of Asoka were first deciphered by James Prinsep in 1837.
- 2 Composed in Prakrit, they were written in Brahmi script in the greater part of the sub-continent.
- 3 In the north-western India, they appeared in Aramaic language and Kharoshti script.
- 4 In Afghanistan, they were written in both Aramaic and Greek scripts and languages.



### *Interesting facts about Ashokan inscriptions*

- The name of Ashoka occurs only in copies of **Minor Rock Edict I** found at 3 places in Karnataka and at one in Madhya Pradesh.
- All the other inscriptions mention only “Devenampiya Piyadasi” meaning dear to gods and leave out the word Ashoka

# MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

## ARCHAEOLOGICAL SOURCES

### EDICTS OF ASHOKA



Ashoka Pillar Edict

- 5 There are fourteen Major Rock Edicts. The **XIII Major Rock Edict** gives details about his war with Kalinga.
- 6 The major pillar edicts were erected in important cities.
- 7 The **Pillar Edict VII** gives a summary of his efforts to promote the **Dhamma** within his kingdom.

# MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

## ARCHAEOLOGICAL SOURCES

### EDICTS OF ASHOKA



**Ashoka Rock Edict**

**8** There are **minor Rock Edicts** and **minor pillar Edicts**. These Edicts of Asoka deal with Asoka's instructions given to his officials and people.

**9** Thus the Asokan inscriptions remain valuable sources for the study of Asoka and the Mauryan Empire.

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# ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

3

## STUPAS



Sanchi stupa

**1** A Stupa is a hemispherical mound shaped construction, which contains holy relics or cremated remains of Buddha and other monks.

**2** They were prevalent in India from the Vedic period. It is conventional representation of a funeral structure in which relics and ashes of the dead were kept.

# ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

3

STUPAS



**Dhamek stupa at Sarnath**

- 3** From the time Ashoka divided up the existing relics of the Buddha and erected monuments to enshrine them, the stupas became objects of cult worship.
- 4** During the period of Ashoka the art of stupas reached its climax almost 84,000 stupas were erected during his period.
- 5** Although a Vedic tradition, stupas were popularised by the Buddhists after the death of the Buddha.

# ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

3

## STUPAS

- 6** Nine stupas were erected; eight of them had relics of the Buddha, while the ninth had the pot in which these relics were originally kept.

### *What does the Buddhist scriptures say?*

The locations of nine stupas were built after the death of the Buddha are

- 1) Rajagriha,
- 2) Vaishali,
- 3) Kapilvasthu,
- 4) Allakappa,
- 5) Ramagrama,
- 6) Pawa,
- 7) Kushinagar
- 8) Pippalvina
- 9) Vethadipa

### *What does the Buddhist scriptures say?*

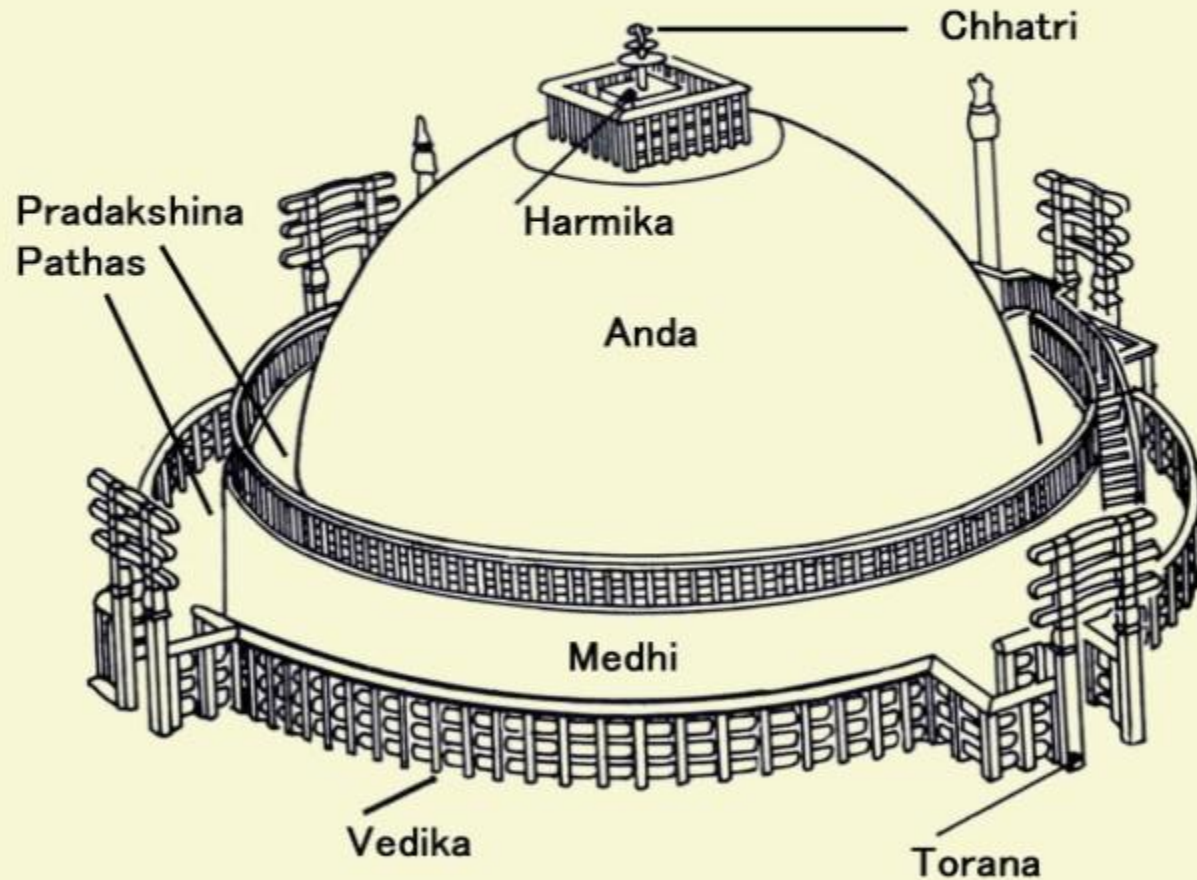
According to the **Mahaparinibban-Sutta**, finally it was decided to distribute the mortal remains of Lord Buddha among eight republics — King Ajatshatru of Magadh (**Rajgir**, Nalanda), The Mallas of **Kushinagar** (UP), the Mallas of **Pava** (Saran, Bihar), the Brahman of **Vethadipa** (Bettiah, Bihar), the Bulis of **Alakappa** (Saran), the Sakyas of **Kapilvastu** (UP), the Koliyas of **Ramagram** (Nepal) and the Republic of the Licchavi of **Vaishali**.

# ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

3

STUPAS

## STRUCTURE OF A STUPA



1

The semicircular mound of earth is called **Anda**, which is the structure of the simplest of the Stupa. This is usually made up of mud and bricks.

2

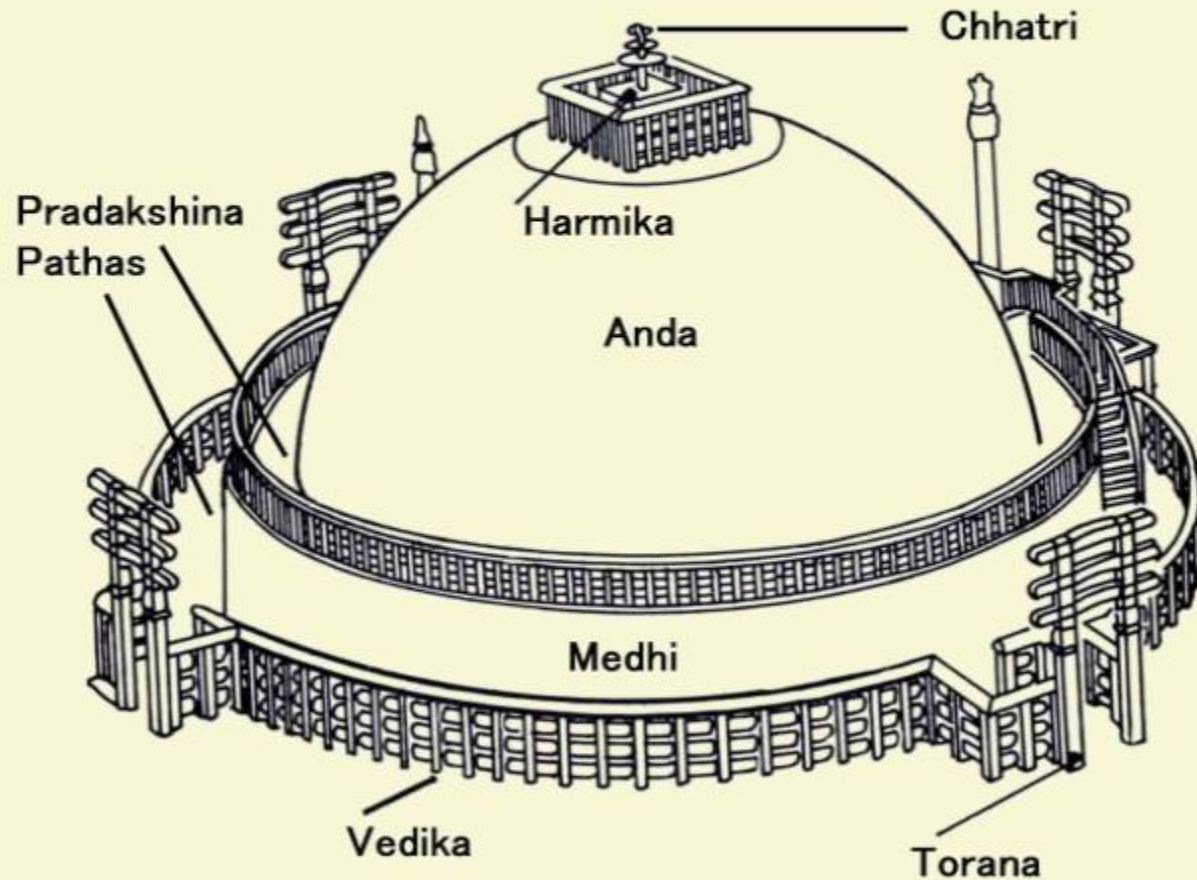
The core of the stupa was made of the unburnt brick, while the outer surface of the stupa were made of the burnt bricks, which was then covered with a thick layer of plaster.

# ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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## STUPAS

### STRUCTURE OF A STUPA



3

The stupas of later period have a balcony above the Anda called Harmika which is representative of the Abode of the Gods.

4

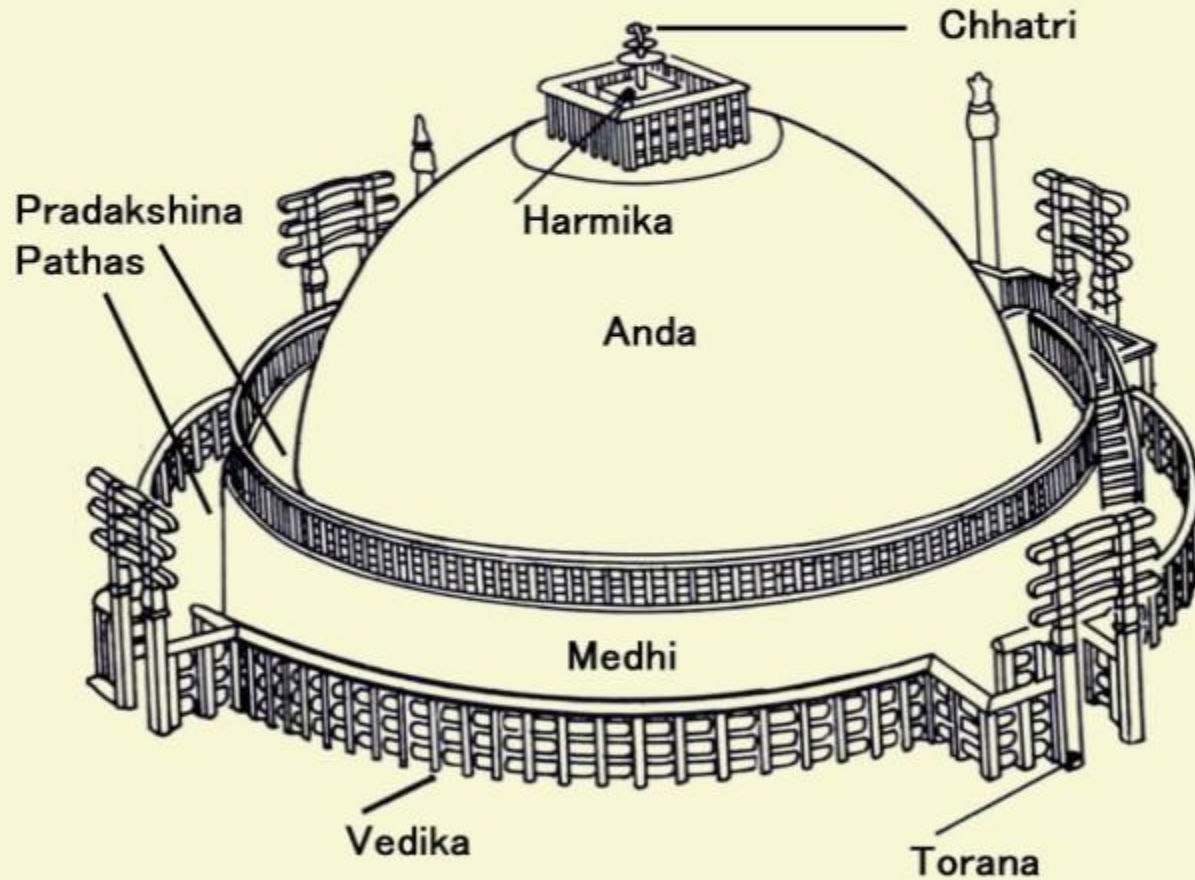
Usually, a mast also arises from the Harmika. This is called Yashti.

# ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

3

## STUPAS

### STRUCTURE OF A STUPA



#### Philosophical symbolization of the Stupa

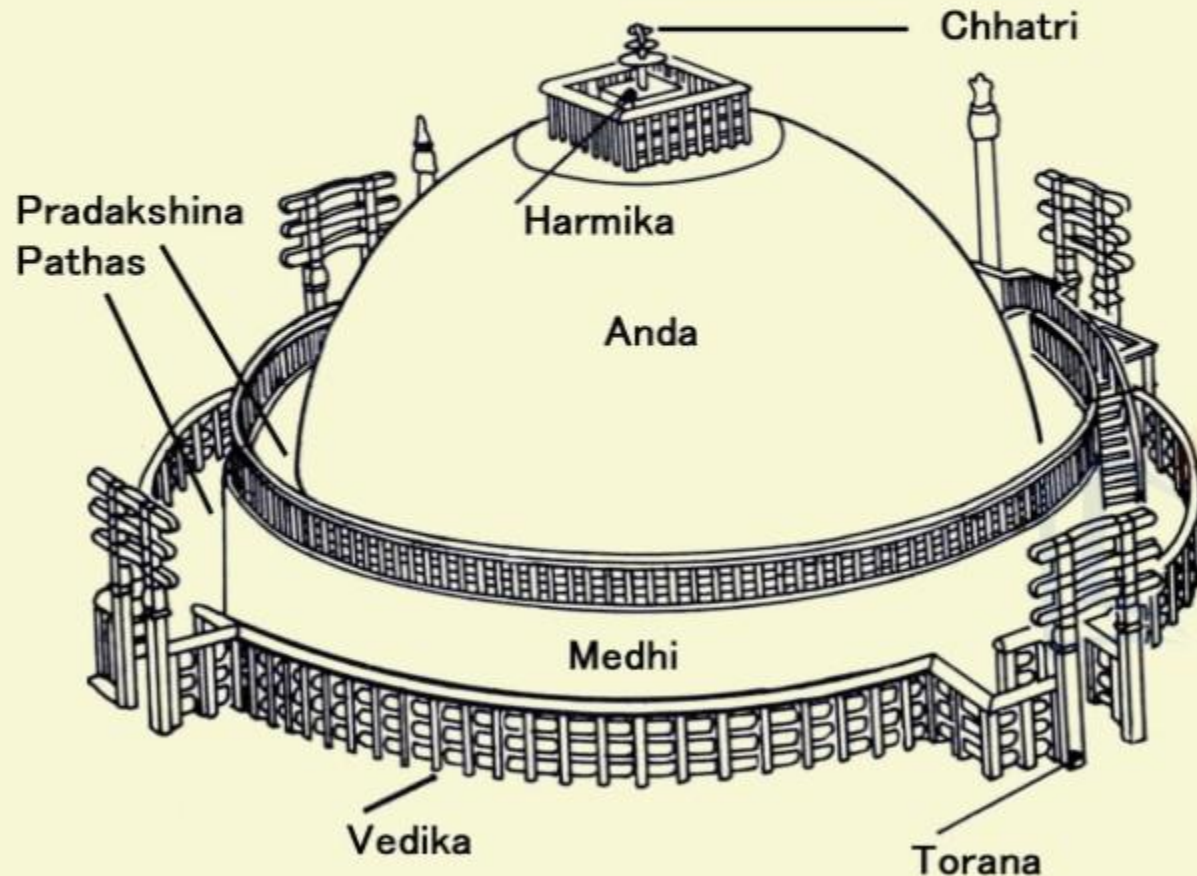
- The stupa itself consists of a base, bearing a hemispherical dome (anda), symbolizing the **dome of heaven enclosing the earth**.
- It is surmounted by a squared rail unit (harmika) representing **the world mountain**, from which rises a mast (yashti), symbolizing the **cosmic axis**.
- The mast bears umbrellas (chatras) that represent the **various heavens (devaloka)**.

# ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

3

STUPAS

## STRUCTURE OF A STUPA



**5** Some stupas also have a railing surrounding it, which serves to separate the sacred place of stupa.

**6** Later, Stupas also had an outer circumambulatory path with railings called **vedika** and decorative gateways called **thoranas**.

# ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

3

STUPAS

## STRUCTURE OF A STUPA



Ruins of the Amaravathi stupa

7

The most prominent example of stupa built by emperor Ashoka is the Sanchi Stupa. Other famous stupas of the ancient time are the Amravathi Stupa in Andhra Pradesh, Dhamek stupa at Sarnath (UP), Ramabhar stupa at Kushinagar (UP), Vaishali stupa in Bihar.

8

However, these Stupas were not in good state of preservation as the stupa at Sanchi.

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